

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

11
LWE-affected districts, down from 126 in 2014; only 3 remain 'most-affected'

607
Maoist leaders and cadre killed in the past two years; 2,000 arrested, 2,850 surrendered

PEACE PATROL
A commando unit of the Chhattisgarh Police keeping vigil in Dantewada, November 2024

NAXALISM

READY FOR THE ENDGAME

The Red Corridor narrows as the State presses its final push against Maoist insurgency through force and persuasion



The Narendra Modi government's war against Left-wing Extremism is entering what it sees as its endgame. The approach has been stark and unmistakable: unrelenting security operations to break armed capability, paired with development, rehabilitation and inducements to hollow out the insurgency.

Intelligence-led operations, deep jungle penetration, drones, fortified police stations and expanded road access have steadily erased Maoist safe havens. The squeeze has fractured leadership and morale, triggering a wave of surrenders—nearly 2,000 cadres laid down arms in 2025 alone, including senior operatives in Bastar. The killing of Madvi Hidma, among the most feared commanders of the Communist Party of India (Maoist), has delivered an even sharper blow to the movement.

The shift is visible on the map: the reach of Maoism has contracted from 126 districts to barely 11. Union home minister Amit Shah has publicly set March 2026 as the deadline to make India "totally free" of it. Critics caution against triumphalism. But Modi has signalled the next phase: consolidating security gains with development in areas freed from the gun. ■

◀ **Winning the War**
Mar. 17, 2025

"Back in Puvarti, the CRPF camp is being decorated with party lights, chairs and tables are being arranged, and sound systems readied for what seem like preparations for a dinner party.... There is hope that the dark night of Naxal violence will end soon, and they, along with the rest of the country, will enjoy the clear blue skies of peace."